

institutes recognised by the All India Council of Technical Education (A.I.C.T.E.).

Those willing to pursue higher education should opt for M. Tech. courses with a specialisation in telecommunications technology and management. One can opt either for a core technology area or for a specialisation in the management aspect of the telecom industry.

The telecom education curriculum covers subjects on telecom regulatory policies, which are essential knowledge for all aspirants. Telecom companies have begun to collaborate with the top educational institutions to improve the curriculum and also directly pull in skilled, qualified engineers.

Skills

Those with hands-on knowledge of installing, maintaining, and troubleshooting equipment are sought after. That apart, "The telecom industry looks to employ candidates with relevant experience. There are not too many telecom companies in India, so employees at the higher management level keep shuffling only between these few companies," says a telecom industry official who requested anonymity. This means it is a kind of "closed circle," meaning one cannot hop between job profiles as easily as in other industries—and that in turn means one needs to develop deep expertise in one specific area.

On the hardware side of the industry, experienced candidates with industry certifications are given first preference. Soft skills are a must at any level. Leadership skills, presentation skills, and such are also necessary. "Experience in the relevant field and industry certification is the prerequisite, and most positions emphasise soft skills," says Karim.

Freshers, Take Note

As mentioned earlier, the industry believes in hiring experienced and qualified candidates. Internships are offered to students and fresh graduates. Engineers who pass out of engineering colleges *might* get an equal chance.

Companies access their potential recruits through placement consultants, employee referrals, and advertisements. Campus recruitment for hardware functions is not common—it

Engineers who pass out of engineering colleges *might* get an equal chance

is more for software functions that freshers are recruited off campuses.

According to L K Bhatia, vice president of the resource management group, Tech Mahindra Ltd, "The expansion of the education system in general—and catching people young to put them into different streams of their interest and aptitude—could speed up the recruitment process. Taking higher technical education to tier 2 and tier 3 cities could uncover a vast pool of talent."

Fresh recruits undergo induction and training for a period ranging from seven days to six months. Classroom training sessions are often organised for officials and engineers working on new technologies adopted by a company. Training sessions are held by product (such as routers and switchers) vendors to enhance skills in the context of the use of the product.

The Money...

The remuneration offered by any telecom company would, in general, be competitive. A majority of employees keep job-hopping until they have the expertise and experience to grow vertically, like we hinted at earlier.

At the entry level, salaries offered range from Rs 1.5 to 3 lakh per annum. This can shoot to Rs 20 lakh per annum for technical positions, and for management positions, the remuneration can cross that figure.

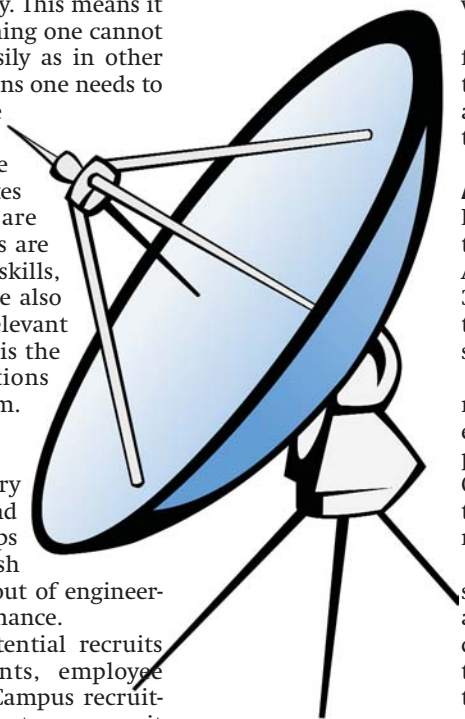
A Parting Word

Projects, technologies, and operations in the telecom industry are in a phase of expansion. A mention should be made of the ingress of 3G technologies. Most of the opportunities in this field come under the umbrella of the service industry.

However, service providers outsource their IT needs; Bharti has recently outsourced to IBM, for example. Network needs are outsourced to product vendors to leverage their expertise. Opportunities related to IT in telecommunications therefore lie also in those organisations, and not only with the service providers themselves.

Do take note: this industry demands super-specialisation in a specific area—you can't move around easily between domains. Choose that domain wisely, and you can be a proud architect or facilitator of one of the most fundamental of human needs: communication. ☐

samir_makwana@thinkdigit.com



The Number One
Technology Destination

www.zdnetindia.com